

HUSAIN NAMA
'Bharat Bhagya Vidhata', acrylic on canvas, 1990

eloquent or poetic than that. In refusing to differentiate between the divine and the human, he gave us stories as they have been passed down over the generations."

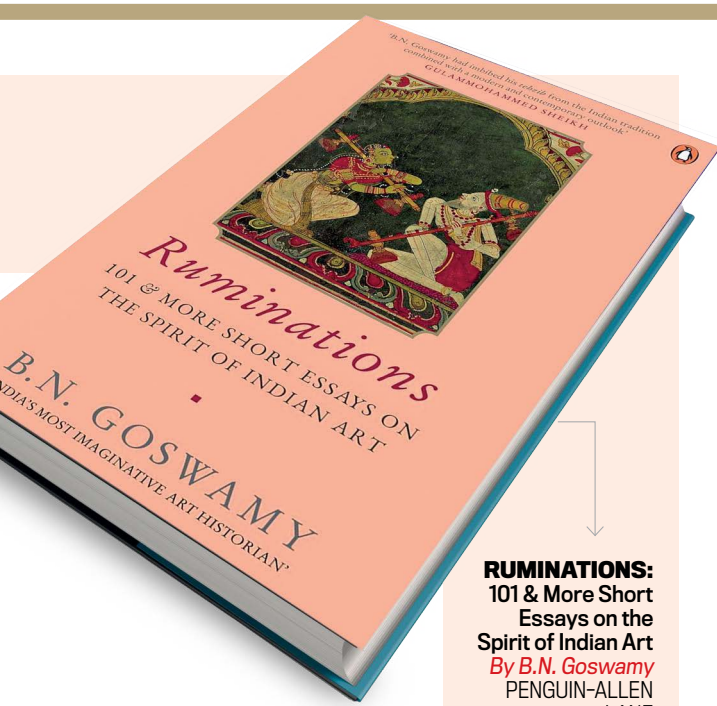
While learning his craft in the 1930s and '40s, two developments played major roles in Husain's career. One, he kept travelling through Rajasthan, capturing the scenes he saw in his usual brisk manner. Many paintings set in Rajasthan are part of *The Timeless Modernist*. Husain would go on to direct *Through the Eyes of a Painter* (1967), a National Award-winning short film which has no dialogue, just long, lingering scenes of village life in Rajasthan. The other was Husain drawing film posters and hoardings to make ends meet. This practice would sharpen his visual sense as well as his distinctive flamboyance. While his trademark 'modified cubist' style was still a while away from fully manifesting itself, the movie-poster work highlights his mastery over light and shadow, his eye for the cinematic moment. "He took on painting posters as a means of survival but it resulted in developing great respect for popular culture in his mind,"

Husain painting film posters for survival honed his visual sense and his distinctive flamboyance

says Anand. "No wonder he ended up making a documentary and feature films. Of course, in terms of practice, the ability to paint free-hand on large canvases has been attributed to his working on hoardings at the start of his career. Husain had the ability to translate his experiences into great art. And if that vision was cinematic, we know what its catalyst was."

Husain's depictions of himself are doubly intriguing. He wasn't quite a Gandhian, despite his many renditions of the Mahatma. And yet, in one of his paintings (later a part of the 1989 series 'Autobiography XIV'), he draws himself in a Gandhi topi, sitting on the floor of a classroom. A nearby wall has the Mahatma's image, bare-chested and clad only in a dhoti. Significantly, the blackboard features lines from a hadith attributed to the Prophet. This work unites several strands of Husain's career—the 'nation-building' depictions, the religious influence and the emphasis on a secular education embodied via Gandhi. *The Timeless Modernist* does a great job of contextualising works like this one—both Husain diehards and newbies will find plenty to ponder here. ■

Aditya Mani Jha



RUMINATIONS:
101 & More Short Essays on the Spirit of Indian Art
By B.N. Goswamy
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of glowing miniature palettes.

There is very strong criticism in one of the texts about our museums and those who run them—not as facilitating, responsible custodians but as people whose job seems to ensure that nothing is shared with anybody. "It is as if they are there only for doing—in most cases, not doing—their job," he writes.

Goswamy's gaze is not about fake eulogies and hagiographies for charlatans. BNG strikes subtly or bluntly as the occasion demands: a bad book on Himachal is wiped close to becoming blank pages; praise for Roerich he turns around, through evidence, into calumny. My detailed appraisal here of many such cases should not spoil the reading of either the euphoric praise or criticism, which is both scathing or amusingly couched in the author's euphemisms. Despite his deep knowledge, when he is uncertain about which of his many interpretations could be right, BNG frames it as an unanswered question rather than pass easy judgement. He remained professor emeritus of art history at Panjab University till his passing. You need only one man like him to disprove the thoughtless humour of those who say that the only culture of the Punjab is agriculture! ■

–Aman Nath